

■ SOUTHERN LATITUDES

Looking north, the Great Square of Pegasus is centrally placed. It is formed by three stars in the winged horse Pegasus, to the left, and one star in the mythological princess, Andromeda, to the right. The horse flies toward



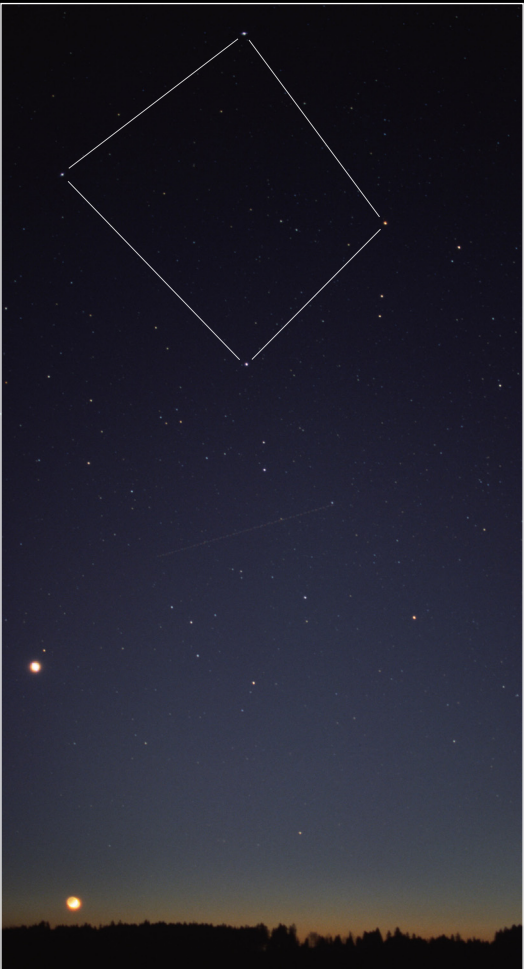
the west. His head is defined by a line of stars; below, two more lines map out his forelegs. The square makes the shape of his upper body.

Andromeda is lower in the sky and to the right of Pegasus. Alpheratz, its brightest star, marks the princess’s head and is the fourth star in the Great Square. The Andromeda Galaxy (M31) is in her left knee. This spiral—similar to but larger than the Milky Way and 2.5 million light-years away—appears as an elongated oval to the naked eye. Its spiral arms and two companion galaxies, M32 and M110, are seen through a larger telescope. A small telescope will reveal NGC 7662, the Blue Snowball planetary nebula near Andromeda’s right hand.

The bright star Fomalhaut, in Piscis Austrinus, is almost overhead. The winter trio of stars Altair, Vega, and Deneb is setting in the northwest. The summer constellations Taurus and Orion are beginning to appear in the east. Only one bright star, Achernar (Eridanus), is high above the horizon to the south. Four relatively dim constellations depicting birds—Phoenix, Grus, Tucana, and Pavo—are center stage. Tucana is well placed for observing the Small Magellanic Cloud and 47 Tucanae. Close to the southeastern horizon is Dorado, significant because it contains the Large Magellanic Cloud, the larger and closer of our two companion galaxies.

Large Magellanic Cloud

Binoculars and a small telescope reveal star clusters and nebulous gas and dust patches in the Large Magellanic Cloud. On its upper-left edge is the Tarantula Nebula, including a cluster of newborn stars. The Large Magellanic Cloud appears to the naked eye as a long hazy patch of light.



Pegasus, the winged horse

The Great Square of Pegasus forms the upper body of the horse. His head is here below the square, and his forelegs stretch off the image at the right. The star at the left in the square belongs to Andromeda. The Moon is seen close to the horizon, and above it is the planet Venus.